

Adoption of Generative AI in Mid-Market Professional Services Firms: A Capability-Based Study of Implementation Outcomes

Dissertation — Doctor of Business Administration

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Abstract

Generative AI promises productivity gains for professional services, yet adoption outcomes vary widely among similar firms. Grounded in the dynamic-capabilities view, this dissertation uses a sequential mixed-methods design, a survey of 211 mid-market firms followed by case studies of six, to explain why some firms convert generative AI pilots into durable value while others stall. Successful adopters were distinguished not by technology spend but by sensing, integrating, and reconfiguring capabilities, especially workflow redesign and governance for human oversight. The study offers a capability roadmap for firms moving from experimentation to scaled, governed use.

Chapter 1: Introduction

Mid-market professional services firms, in law, accounting, consulting, and design, face pressure to adopt generative AI, but many pilots fail to scale. The puzzle is that firms with similar tools and budgets achieve very different outcomes, suggesting the decisive factor lies in organizational capability rather than technology.

This dissertation asks which capabilities separate firms that realize durable value from those that stall, and how governance for human oversight shapes outcomes. It frames the question through the dynamic-capabilities lens.

Chapter 2: Literature Review and Framework

The technology-adoption and dynamic-capabilities literatures explain that value comes not from acquiring a technology but from sensing opportunities, seizing them through investment and redesign, and reconfiguring the organization. Prior generative-AI research is largely anecdotal and skewed toward large enterprises.

This study addresses the gap with a capability-based framework applied specifically to mid-market firms, and it treats governance and human oversight as part of the seizing and reconfiguring capabilities rather than as an afterthought.

Chapter 3: Methods

A sequential explanatory design was used. First, a survey of 211 mid-market professional services firms measured capability constructs and self-reported adoption outcomes, analyzed with regression. Second, six firms spanning strong and weak outcomes were selected for comparative case studies using interviews and document review.

Construct validity, common-method safeguards, and the case-selection logic are described, along with the integration strategy linking quantitative associations to qualitative mechanisms.

Chapter 4: Findings

In the survey, reconfiguration and integration capabilities predicted adoption outcomes, while raw technology spend did not. Firms reporting formal human-oversight governance reported better and more

durable outcomes.

The case studies clarified the mechanism: successful firms redesigned workflows around the tool and established review checkpoints, whereas stalled firms bolted the tool onto unchanged processes and lacked accountability for output quality.

Chapter 5: Discussion

The convergence of findings supports a capability-based explanation of generative-AI value: outcomes hinge on organizational sensing, integration, reconfiguration, and governance, not on spend. This extends dynamic-capabilities theory to a fast-moving general-purpose technology and offers managers a concrete roadmap.

Limitations include self-reported outcomes, cross-sectional survey timing, and six cases from one economy. Common-method and generalizability threats and their mitigations are discussed.

Chapter 6: Conclusion

This dissertation explained variation in generative-AI adoption among mid-market professional services firms through a capability lens, identifying workflow reconfiguration and oversight governance as decisive. The contribution is both theoretical, extending dynamic capabilities, and practical, a staged roadmap from pilot to governed scale. Future work should track outcomes longitudinally as the technology matures.

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